

A Call To Collect(ive)

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Novels are supposed to be fun and yet, there are so many not fun feelings about the novel coronavirus pandemic. The loudest feeling I remember from that time was wanting to feel connected. Twitter, TikTok, Instagram Lives! Hot and dirty martinis!!! But after a few months of blacking out on Zoom with friends, I started to feel like I existed online and nowhere else. We weren't given an end date and at some point in May, it started to feel like this was going to be forever. I started to see people moving back home enmasse. Back to the people they belonged to.

There were two types of families during the pandemic: Families who quarantined and tested to spend time with each other during the holidays, and people who have never been within an inch of a PCR test and went to Tulum twice. I know them both, I love them both, but my family is neither. I guess the best way I can convey my family's ideology is how my mom told me that when her twin sister asked for a hug on Christmas (2020), she declined because she was worried she might have taken in the mail and could pass the virus to her. My mother and her sister both hadn't left the house since March or made physical contact with any other people.

The pandemic was painful. Agonizing. We were all operating under information that was mercurial. Moving back home wasn't an option and if truly belonging even kind of means that people have to want you too — where was I supposed to go? I started begging friends to meet at a park and prayed we would get sooo lost in conversation (from six feet away) that we might accidentally hug goodbye. And when I got hugs, I journaled about them. I received eleven hugs in 2020. When I discovered that we benefit most from twelve hugs a day (seriously, google it!), I realized that no one was leaving this... intact. Dare I posit that no one escaped the pandemic without acquiring one of the following: a lapse in employment, a mortgage, a different sexual orientation, a baby, or a traumatic loss that still leaves them speechless.

I will be unpacking the last three years for the next ten and... I'd like you to join me. I believe the pandemic was a crisis of unbelonging. The cost of unbelonging is only worth it if we can talk about it. I can't disassociate anymore and I hope that through conversations, we can find each other and foster a deep knowing. An acknowledgment of our triumphs and our despairs. An environment that will make room for us and all the hugs we missed.

I write this as an invitation. What was the cost of your unbelonging? Who have you been and what have you left behind? Where do you belong now?

The background is a vibrant, abstract composition of overlapping colors including deep purple, bright yellow, and teal. A faint, light-colored grid pattern is visible across the entire image, creating a textured, layered effect.

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